

Gay
NEW YORK

*Gender, Urban Culture,
and the Making of the
Gay Male World,
1890—1940*

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Chapter 2

THE FAIRY AS AN INTERMEDIATE SEX

THE STRIKING IMAGE OF THE “MALE DEGENERATES” OR “FAIRIES” CONGREGATING at Paresis Hall and the other Bowery resorts forcefully undermines the familiar presumption that homosexuals were isolated from one another and that homosexuality itself was all but invisible in turn-of-the-century New York. But it also presents us with a picture of male sexual identities and practices different from the one predominant at our end of the century. The “female impersonators” on display at the Bowery resorts were the most famous symbols of gay life, and the impression of that life they conveyed was reinforced by the countless other effeminate men who were visible in the streets of the city’s working-class and amusement districts in the early decades of the century. As Mary Casal recalled of her tour of the Bowery resorts, “Seeing hundreds of male inverts . . . gathered together in a group made it easy to recognize them on any occasion where we might meet or see them, and so avoid any contact.”¹ They were not the only homosexually active men in New York, but they constituted the primary image of the “invert” in popular and elite discourse alike and stood at the center of the cultural system by which male–male sexual relations were interpreted. As the dominant pejorative category in opposition to which male sexual “normality” was defined, the fairy influenced the culture and self-understanding of *all* sexually active men. The fairy thus offers a key to the cultural archaeology of male sexual practices and mentalities in this era and to the configuration of sex, gender, and sexuality in the early twentieth century.²

The determinative criterion in the identification of men as fairies was not the extent of their same-sex desire or activity (their “sexuality”), but rather the gender persona and status they assumed.³ It was only the men

who assumed the sexual and other cultural roles ascribed to women who identified themselves—and were identified by others—as fairies. The fairies' sexual desire for men was not regarded as the singular characteristic that distinguished them from other men, as is generally the case for gay men today. That desire was seen as simply one aspect of a much more comprehensive gender role inversion (or reversal), which they were also expected to manifest through the adoption of effeminate dress and mannerisms; they were thus often called *inverts* (who had “inverted” their gender) rather than *homosexuals* in technical language. In the dominant turn-of-the-century cultural system governing the interpretation of homosexual behavior, especially in working-class milieus, one had a *gender* identity rather than a *sexual* identity or even a “sexuality”; one's sexual behavior was thought to be necessarily determined by one's gender identity. (Or, to put it in other words, since the language is notoriously ambiguous here, one had an identity based on one's gender rather than on one's “sexuality,” which was not regarded as a distinct domain of personhood but as a pattern of practices and desires that followed inevitably from one's masculinity or femininity.) Sexual desire for men was held to be inescapably a woman's desire, and the *inverts*' desire for men was not seen as an indication of their “homosexuality” but as simply one more manifestation of their fundamentally womanlike character. The fundamental division of male sexual actors in much of turn-of-the-century working-class thought, then, was not between “heterosexual” and “homosexual” *men*, but between conventionally masculine males, who were regarded as men, and effeminate males, known as fairies or *pansies*, who were regarded as virtual women, or, more precisely, as members of a “third sex” that combined elements of the male and female. The heterosexual–homosexual binarism that governs our thinking about sexuality today, and that, as we shall see, was already becoming hegemonic in middle-class sexual ideology, did not yet constitute the common sense of working-class sexual ideology.

The numerous treatises on sexual inversion prepared by doctors and gay intellectuals at the turn of the century help explicate (even if they did not determine) the terms of the cultural system by which homosexual behavior was understood. The centrality of gender inversion to the culture's understanding of what we would now term homosexual desire is evident in the explanations they offered for men who sexually desired other men. For instance, Dr. William Lee Howard argued in 1904 that the *inverts*' “sexual desire for their—apparent—own sex” was “really a *normal* sexual feeling,” because the *inverts* were actually *women* (who naturally desired men) even though they *appeared* to be men (for whom

such desire would have been perverted). He explained this apparent paradox by asserting that although the inverts had male bodies, they had female brains, and by reminding his readers that the brain, rather than the anatomy, was “the primary factor” in classifying the sex of a person.⁴ Most of the other doctors writing about inversion in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries adopted a related approach by conceptualizing fairies (as well as lesbians or “lady lovers”) as a “third sex” or an “intermediate sex” between men and women, rather than as men or women who were also “homosexuals.”⁵

Most gay intellectuals writing in Europe and the United States shared this perspective. In the 1860s, Karl Ulrichs, the first German writer (and for decades the only openly “inverted” man) to discuss inversion in a public forum, did not define it in the same terms now used for homosexuality, but characterized the *Urning* (his term for an invert) as representing a “woman’s spirit in a man’s body.” At the turn of the century, many of the next generation of gay intellectuals, including Edward Carpenter in Britain and Magnus Hirschfeld in Germany, adopted a version of this theory, claiming that they were best characterized as a “third sex” or an “intermediate sex” (the loose but popular translation of *sexuelle Zwischenstufe*), hermaphroditically combining psychic qualities of both the male and female. This was also the distinction made by Marcel Proust in his classic account of inversion, the *Sodom and Gomorrah* volume of *Remembrance of Things Past*.⁶

This mode of conceptualizing the character of inverts was strikingly indicated by the meaning such writers gave the term *bisexual*. By the mid-twentieth century, when a system categorizing people on the basis of their sexual object-choice had largely replaced one categorizing them on the basis of gender style, the word referred to individuals sexually attracted to both men and women. At the turn of the century, however, *bisexual* referred to individuals who combined the physical and/or psychic attributes of both men and women. A bisexual was not *attracted* to both males and females; a bisexual *was* both male and female.⁷

The prominence of the fairy in turn-of-the-century New York and his consistency with the hegemonic gender ideology of the era made him the dominant—and most plausible—role model available to boys and men trying to make sense of vague feelings of sexual and gender difference. The model of the fairy offered many men a means of constructing public personas they considered more congruent with their “inner natures” than conventional masculine ones, but that were also consistent with the terms of the dominant gender culture in which they had been socialized and that had, therefore, helped constitute those “inner natures.” Taking on

the role of the fairy, that is, allowed them to reject the kind of masculinity prescribed for them by the dominant culture, but to do so without rejecting the hegemonic tenets of their culture concerning the gender order. As we shall see, many men rejected the role of the fairy as inconsistent with their male identities (or as too dangerous to their status as men), or only identified themselves as fairies before discovering there were alternative ways of being gay. But many other men embraced the identity because it embodied a way of understanding how they, as men, could have the feelings their culture ascribed exclusively to women.

THE SEMIOTICS OF INVERSION: EFFEMINACY AS A CULTURAL STRATEGY

The feminine character ascribed to the fairies is shown most clearly by the highly gendered—and engendering—signs that others used to identify them. When an anti-vice agent who investigated Paresis Hall in 1899 wished to illustrate the effeminacy of the “degenerates” he had seen there, he cited a wide range of womanlike characteristics as particularly revealing: not only did the men there solicit normal men—such as the investigator himself—for “immoral purposes,” but they were “painted and powdered,” used women’s names, and displayed feminine mannerisms (or “aped the female character”).⁸ The adoption of these signs was critical to the process whereby many men transformed their self-identity—or at least their public persona—into that of a fairy. Some men embraced such styles as more “natural” to them than conventional masculine styles, so they help explain how men who had been raised to be “normal” used the role of the fairy to come to terms with their sense of sexual difference from other men. Other men adopted such signs as part of a cultural strategy that allowed them to negotiate the terms of their relationships with other men, and they highlight the dynamics of that strategy. Their centrality to gay culture and their utility as a means of identifying “fairies” suggests they provide an unexpected prism for viewing the cultural construction of gender in the era.

Like the men at Paresis Hall who called themselves “Princess this and Lady So and So and the Duchess of Marlboro,” most fairies adopted women’s names as part of the process by which they constructed a gay persona. Many men chose campy, flamboyant women’s names or nicknames (such as Queen Mary, Salome, Cinderella, Violet, Blossom, Edna May, and Big Tess), feminine nicknames that highlighted a personal characteristic (such as Dixie, Gaby, Chuckles), names that played on their own names (Max might become Maxine), or the names of well-known women performers. By the 1910s and 1920s, they often borrowed the names of movie stars whose images resonated in some way with gay culture, each name evoking the partic-

ular feminine persona associated with the actress. Some men, for instance, adopted the name of Theda Bara, the classic vamp in the films of the mid-1910s, who portrayed erotically aggressive women capable of enervating the strongest of men. In the succeeding two decades, Gloria Swanson, an actress known for both her numerous marriages and her wardrobe, was perhaps the most popular of drag personas, and was taken as the *nom de drag* by the best-known African-American drag queen of the 1930s (see chapter 9). Mae West was a popular drag name by the early thirties.⁹

Adopting a woman's name not only announced a man's gay identity and perhaps something about the persona he sought to cultivate, but marked his transition from the straight world to the gay as well. Some men who permanently joined the sexual underworld, such as entertainers and full-time prostitutes, left their masculine birthnames behind and became known exclusively by their women's names (or camp names). Others, who moved back and forth between the gay world and the straight, used their feminine names only in gay circles, as a way of marking their temporary transition into the gay world; having two names emblemized their participation in a double life. Some of them adopted such pseudonyms when they ventured into the sexual underworld for the same reason many prostitutes did, to conceal and protect their identities in the straight world.¹⁰ For fear of blackmail if his status in the straight world were discovered, "Ralph Werther" (a part-time fairy who later wrote about his experiences) was as careful to hide his straight life from his Bowery associates as he was his gay life from his university colleagues, even giving a false name when asked on the Bowery what his masculine name was. He went by "Jennie June" there (using the pen name of one of the nineteenth century's most famous female journalists), telling his working-class associates that Werther was his legal name, and he authored his first book under yet another pseudonym, Earl Lind.¹¹ Even in later decades, many men went by "bar names" or "camp names" at gay bars or parties, some using them only occasionally and in jest, others using them constantly in order to conceal their straight identities.¹²

Although fairies were known as "female impersonators," transvestism was not central to their self-representation. Relatively few men wore women's clothes, and, given the laws against transvestism (see chapter 10), even most men who wished to don a woman's full wardrobe dared do so only in relatively secure settings, such as a few of the Bowery resorts.¹³ But dressing entirely as a woman was hardly necessary to indicate that one was a fairy. In the right context, appropriating even a single feminine—or at least unconventional—style or article of clothing might signify a man's identity as a fairy. Thus a much larger number of men adopted more subtle, but

still telling, clothing cues; the essential ingredient of a fairy's dress, as Ralph Werther explained, was that it be "as fancy and flashy as a youth dare adopt." He recalled that he "proclaimed myself" as a fairy to working-class youth on Fourteenth Street in the 1890s simply by wearing "white kids [gloves] and [a] large red neck-bow with fringed ends hanging down over my lapels."¹⁴

Writing in the late 1930s or around 1940, a gay man named Thomas Painter described a system guided by similar principles, although adapted in its particulars to contemporary male fashions. He counted "green suits, tight-cuffed trousers, flowered bathing trunks, and half-lengthed flaring top-coats" as distinctively homosexual attire, along with such accessories as "excessively bright feathers in their hat-bands." Dark brown and gray suede shoes were "practically a homosexual monopoly."¹⁵ Writing at about the same time, another gay man, Gershon Legman, included "cosmetics . . . flamboyant clothes and suede or high-heeled shoes" as the insignia of the "flaming queen . . . who attempts thus to attract attention and drum up trade."¹⁶

Some clothes, such as a green suit, were so bold that few dared wear them. Other items of apparel, which sent the same message more subtly, were worn more commonly. Perhaps the most famous of these in the early years of the century was the red tie. By 1916 a physician in Chicago had heard that "male perverts in New York . . . are known as 'fairies' and wear a red necktie," even though, he added, "inverts are generally said to prefer green."¹⁷ Still, the red tie was famous only in certain circles; it was a subtle signal likely to be understood in some contexts more than others. A man wearing a red necktie on a well-known New York cruising street such as Riverside Drive or Fourteenth Street, for instance, was likely to be labeled a fairy. In the early 1910s a New York "invert" explained that "to wear a red necktie on the street is to invite remarks from newsboys and others. . . . A friend told me once that when a group of street boys caught sight of the red necktie he was wearing they sucked their fingers in imitation of *fellatio*."¹⁸ But a man wearing the same tie in a social setting in which people were less alert to such signs might just be considered odd. An unconventional choice in an era of conservative colors, a red tie announced unorthodox tastes of another sort only to those in the know.

Styles of dress, demeanor, and physicality varied among ethnic cultures at any given time. Behavior or attire that signified sexual abnormality in one group might well signify normality—and even affiliation with the group—in another. One man might further the impression of effeminacy by wearing a "necklace"; another might signify his status as a "rough," highly masculine working-class youth by wearing a chain with a cross around his neck. Styles also changed over time. One man

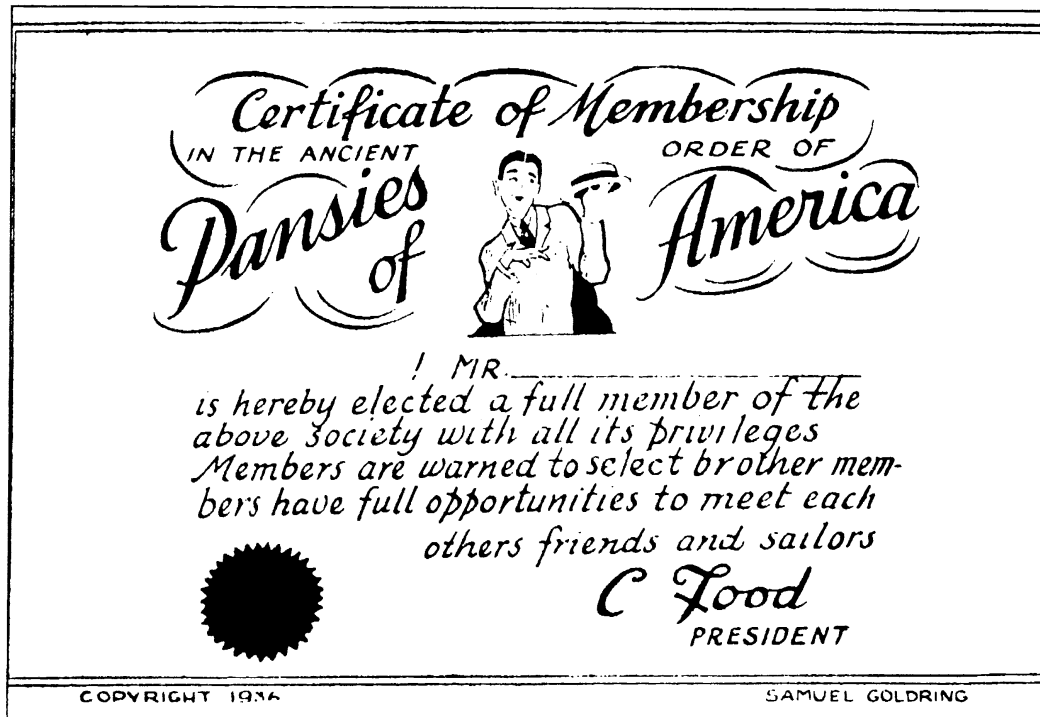


Figure 2.2. This “certificate” circulated among gay men in the 1930s. It can be read as a spoof of pansies or as an assertion by those pansies of their membership in a social group—or both. The “C Food” signature draws on gay slang (“seafood” referred to sailors as sex objects) to make an insider’s joke about the desirability—and availability—of sailors. (From *Yale Collection of American Literature*, Beinecke Rare Books and Manuscripts Library, Yale University.)

active in New York’s gay world since the 1930s noted in the summer of 1951 that the straight white working-class youths from South Brooklyn with whom he associated had suddenly started wearing chartreuse and fuchsia shirts, “for which they would have been hooted off the street and the shirt off their backs, with comments like ‘pansy,’ years ago.” In the meantime, gay men had adopted other styles. Choice in color was not just a marker of gender or sexuality, however. According to the same man, such colors were embraced only by men from certain ethnic backgrounds in the early 1950s. Many Irish youth, he noted a year later, rejected color in male attire in part because “they considered it Latin, or, more to the point, Negro, to effect color.” Whatever the actual patterns of dress, the presumed differences in attitudes toward color in dress became a way Irish and German youths distinguished themselves from Italians, African-Americans, and Puerto Ricans as well as from gay men.¹⁹

Observers often considered the unusual—even fairylike—dress of entertainers, artists, and other professionally colorful personalities to be just another sign of their special status rather than a sign of their sexual

deviance. As a result, however, describing someone as “artistic” could be a coded way of calling him homosexual, and observers often played on the ambiguity in their criticisms of artists. A 1933 *Daily News* profile of the entertainer Harry Richman, full of innuendo that Richman was sexually eccentric, furthered the impression by remarking that Richman had “gone in for gay colored suits recently. He even owns and wears a green suit . . . likes bright underwear and wears only silk . . . [and] likes sapphires and odd-shaped jewelry.”²⁰

Gay men, like most men and women, also sought to engender their bodies by molding them in ways that approximated the ideal gender types of their cultural group. Like other people, in other words, they undertook artificial means to cultivate the shape, density, carriage, and texture of their bodies, which they nonetheless continued to regard as the natural repository and signifier of their “sex.”²¹ Every aspect of their bodies’ appearance was densely gendered, but they paid particular attention—like their “normal” counterparts, but with different goals in mind—to the ways they cut, styled, and colored their hair, painted and scented their faces, and grew, shaved, penciled, or tore out their eyebrows and other facial hair, as well as to the ways they walked, sat, spoke, moved their eyes, and carried their heads, hands, arms, and legs.

Perhaps most commonly, men used unconventional styles in personal grooming to signal their anomalous gender status. “Plucked eyebrows, rouged lips, powdered face, and marcelled, blondined hair” were the essential attributes of the fairy, one straight observer noted in 1933, succinctly summarizing the characteristics at least two generations of New Yorkers had used to identify such men.²² In his 1934 painting *The Fleet’s In*, the gay painter Paul Cadmus signaled the sexual character of a male civilian offering a cigarette to a sailor by giving him precisely such features—as well as a red tie (as shown in figure 3.1). The fairies’ “painted and powdered” faces were usually the first thing visitors to the Bowery resorts commented on in the 1890s, and Ralph Werther identified several “low class fairies” in a Bowery saloon in the same period partly on the basis of their “hair a la mode de Oscar Wilde (that is, hanging down in ringlets over the ears and collar).”²³ In 1922 a seventeen-year-old Italian boy told of being arrested with a friend in Prospect Park when a detective “took off our hats and saw that our eyebrows were tweezed [and] said, ‘You are fairies.’”²⁴ That the detective’s surmise about the meaning of tweezed eyebrows was widely shared was confirmed not only by the boys’ efforts to hide their telltale eyebrows with hats but also by an eighteen-year-old’s assertion, a few years later, that it was “common knowledge” among the boys in his Italian Harlem neighborhood that “men with full faces, long delicate fingers, tweezed eyebrows and well shaped lips are invert.”²⁵

As investigators' descriptions of Paresis Hall and other gay resorts suggest, some gay men reinforced the image conveyed by their grooming by using a variety of other gender codes in their carriage, demeanor, and speech, which identified them as gay to straight and gay men alike. In explaining how he identified homosexuals at the bars he investigated, one government agent noted in the 1930s that "the most striking feature [of homosexuals] would be the fact that although they represent and are dressed as one sex they act and impersonate the opposite sex . . . by gesture, voice inflection, manner or mode of speech, or walk, and in general [they] impersonate all of the other characteristics of a female that they can possibly assume."²⁶

While his use of such stereotypical signs to identify homosexuals might seem incredible to the present reader, gay men used them as well. Ralph Werther immediately discerned that a group of men he met in 1895 were fairies on the basis of "the timbre of their voices . . . and their feminesque mannerisms."²⁷ The way men walked and carried their arms and hands were also taken as clues to their sexual identities. A limp wrist or an exaggerated swivel-hipped, mincing walk—known as "swishing" in the gay world—was regularly caricatured on the vaudeville stage and occasionally seen on the street as a sign of the "true" fairy. But more subtle stances were also read as gender-specific. Whereas a "normal" man rarely stood with his hands on his hips, according to a gay writer in 1941, when he did so it was "with his thumbs back and his fingers forward, his elbows straight out or somewhat backward." By contrast, he thought, a "very effeminate homosexual" was more likely to adopt such a pose, and to place "his thumbs *forward* and his fingers back, his shoulders hunched somewhat forward, and his head facing to one side."²⁸ A gay sailor, pressed in 1919 to explain how he identified someone as "queer," pointed to less precise but similarly subtle indications of effeminacy: "He acted sort of peculiar; walking around with his hands on his hips. . . . [His] manner was not masculine. . . . The expression with the eyes and the gestures. . . ."²⁹

To dismiss such signs as mere stereotypes is to misapprehend their significance. They *were* stereotypes, to be sure. But the fact that men were identified as fairies on the basis of such minimal and "stereotypical" deviations from the conventions of masculine demeanor and dress indicates the narrow range of deviation from normative gender styles allowed *most* men. It also suggests the extraordinary sensitivity of men to subtle markers of gender status, thus highlighting the pervasive character of gender surveillance in working-class street culture. Furthermore, it confirms what I have already suggested about the articulation of the boundaries of gender and sexuality in the era, for it indicates that an inversion of any one aspect of one's prescribed gender persona was presumed to be sympto-

matic of a much more comprehensive inversion, which inevitably would manifest itself in abnormal sexual object-choice as well.

More significant, in this context, is that the effectiveness of such signs suggests the extraordinary plasticity of gender assignment in the culture in which the fairies operated, and the remarkable ease with which men could construct a public persona as a quasi-woman or fairy. Many more gay men adopted such effeminate mannerisms then than do today because they were so central to the dominant role model available to them as they formed a gay identity. But many men switched the mannerisms on and off as easily as they changed from feminine to more masculine attire, and were able to manipulate such symbols to avoid being labeled fairies. By wearing conventional masculine attire and carrying themselves with a "masculine" demeanor, most men could pass as straight, even if they chose to camp it up when in a secure gay environment.

Perhaps more unexpectedly, many men deliberately *used* such markers in order to signal their sexual character to other gay men and to straight men in public contexts. Effeminacy was one of the few sure means they had to identify themselves to others. As a man who moved to New York from Michigan in the 1920s recalled, "Back in the early twenties, people had to be quite effeminate to be identified, at least that was true in my case."³⁰ His statement implied that he could avoid being identified by avoiding any sign of effeminacy, but his point was that he *chose* to be effeminate precisely because he wanted to identify himself to other men. Another gay man made the same point with a somewhat different emphasis when he commented in the 1920s that the men he knew "talk and act like women, have feminine ways . . . [and] use rouge and powder . . . *in order to attract men.*"³¹

For many men, then, adopting effeminate mannerisms represented a deliberate cultural strategy, as well as a way of making sense of their sense of sexual difference. It was a way to declare a gay identity publicly and to negotiate their relationship with other men. The fairies' effeminacy helped them attract men not only by signaling their interest but also by establishing the cultural script that would govern their social and sexual interactions and reaffirm the cultural distance between them and the men they sought.³² By taking on the role of women and making their violation of gender conventions consistent—by insisting, for instance, that men refer to them with women's names and pronouns—they reaffirmed those conventions in a way that allowed men to interact with them as if they *were* women, even though all parties understood that anatomically they were males. An agent investigating an African-American speakeasy in the basement of a Harlem brownstone in 1928 was approached by a man using

just this strategy. “[He] said to me in a very high pitched voice ‘Oh come, let’s dance, I am a B[itch] like those others sitting over there,’ indicating a group of women.”³³

One indication of the extent to which men became accustomed to thinking of fairies as pseudo-women was provided in 1939 by a State Liquor Authority investigator who casually referred to a fairy (who went by a woman’s name but dressed in conventional male attire) as “she,” even though he was testifying at a formal hearing of the Authority. “We did get in a conversation with Beverly,” he testified, “and she stated she liked us very much.” When asked by an attorney whether he meant “she” or “he,” he explained that the fairies “address themselves by these effeminate names and refer to one another in the effeminate terms,” and promptly continued: “She [the fairy] made a date with Mr. Van Wagner and myself for Saturday night.”³⁴

Much evidence suggests that the fairy, so long as he abided by the conventions of this cultural script, was tolerated in much of working-class society—regarded as an anomaly, certainly, but as more amusing than abhorrent, and only rarely as a threat to the gender order. He was so obviously a “third-sexer,” a different species of human being, that his very effeminacy served to confirm rather than threaten the masculinity of other men, particularly since it often exaggerated the conventions of deference and gender difference between men and women. The fairies reaffirmed the conventions of gender even as they violated them: they behaved as no man should, but as any man might wish a woman would.³⁵ Their representation of themselves as “intermediate types” made it easier for men to interact with them (and even have sex with them) by making it clear who would play the “man’s part” in the interaction.

The conventions governing such interactions were so well established and their meaning so well understood that gay men did not always need to engage in an elaborate performance to signal their character and establish the terms of their interaction with other men. A 1929 account by the young writer Parker Tyler in a letter to a gay friend of his encounter with several men one evening in the Village suggests both the extraordinary effectiveness of these conventions in structuring such interactions and gay men’s ability to play with them:

[A friend] and I were in a speakeasy and four young [men] (I think they were newsreel cameramen) tried to make me, asking to be taken to my apartment. But they were frightfully vulgar; they called me Grace or something, until I insisted on Miss Tyler. It was really amusing, for one made a date with me quite anxiously and quite seriously,

just as though I were a girl. You know the type he is: W - o - l - f. But I stood him up, of course—the little prick!

The young men's interaction with one of Tyler's friends indicates the degree to which the fairy's reconstruction of his gender through his gay cultural style outweighed the physical evidence of his body in determining the men's response to him. "Jules, being drunk, camped with them too, and they tried to date him—even after feeling his muscle: he could have laid them all low: really it's as wide as this paper."³⁶

The presence of fairies at the Bowery resorts in the late nineteenth century provides one sign that they were tolerated by and integrated into working-class culture. Even more significant is the fact that fairies were also tolerated at many working-class dance halls and other meeting places where they were not made an official part of the "show," but interacted more casually with other patrons, albeit often still serving as an informal source of entertainment. At a dance hall opposite Jackson Avenue Park in Brooklyn in 1912, an anti-vice agent witnessed two fairies known as Elsie and Daisy carrying on with a group of young women, borrowing their powder puffs and acting in a "conspicuous way." When many of the men and women moved to the saloon next door after the hall closed at midnight, Elsie and Daisy entertained them with songs "which were obscene to the farthest limit," according to the agent, and later danced together, imitating "the action of committing sodomy," much to the delight of the other youths, who engaged in their own suggestive styles of dancing.³⁷

To say that fairies were tolerated in much of working-class society, however, is not to say that they were respected. The men who became fairies did so at the cost of forfeiting their privileged status as men. Indeed, if working-class gender culture created an opening for fairies, it was a highly contested one, and men had to struggle to claim their place as fairies in the neighborhood. While some men, like Elsie and Daisy, managed to establish a place for themselves in their own neighborhoods, many others sought to minimize the risks involved in carrying themselves as fairies by doing so only in parts of town distant from their homes, where being brutalized or mocked would at least have fewer long-term consequences. The seventeen-year-old Italian mentioned previously, for instance, adopted a conventional persona in his own neighborhood, carrying himself as a fairy (by taking off his hat to reveal his tweezed eyebrows) only in another part of town.

Mockery and contempt often colored the public interactions between men and fairies in the streets and Bowery resorts, although gay men sometimes contested the conventions of ridicule. A 1928 report by an

undercover investigator illustrates this, while also revealing how visible gay men were in working-class neighborhoods and how casually other men interacted with them. In the course of a conversation with the agent, the proprietor of a speakeasy on West Seventeenth Street mentioned the fairies who frequented an Italian restaurant down the street, and the agent asked to see them. The proprietor readily agreed to take him to the restaurant. "It's fun," he declared. "I've been up there lots of times and kidded them along." But he also indicated that the fairies were willing to let the kidding go only so far; "some sure can fight," he added, indicating his respectful recognition that the fairies were prepared to defend themselves if the kidding got out of hand.³⁸ Jimmy Durante's recollection of the "queer entertainers" at the Bowery and Coney Island saloons where he got his start at the turn of the century indicates they had adopted a similar stance: "Some of them were six feet tall and built like Dempsey," he later noted, "so it was never very healthy to make nasty cracks."³⁹

Not all fairies were built like Dempsey, though, and the threat of physical assaults on them was an abiding one. If fairies and other homosexuals were widely recognized as social types in the streets of working-class neighborhoods, they were also regarded as easy marks by the gangs of youths who controlled much of the traffic on those streets. "Go[ing] after fags" was an easy way to make money, observed one nineteen-year-old in an Italian Harlem gang in the early 1930s. The "fags" sometimes paid the boys and young men they met for quick sexual encounters in the parks and movie theaters; even better, they sometimes took the young men home to their apartments. Once they "bring you to an apartment," the nineteen-year-old added, "you just clean it out." The social researcher who interviewed him while studying East Harlem considered "the common practice of exploiting homosexuals" to be as characteristic of such boys' lives as the poolroom and petty thievery.⁴⁰ Even Ralph Werther, who waxed rhapsodic in his memoirs about his playful relationships with Irish and Italian youths in the 1890s and 1900s, repeatedly deplored the fact that such youths felt justified in brutalizing fairies. "The thievishly inclined regularly prey on androgynes," he noted, because they knew the latter were considered "outlaws" by the authorities and thus would not dare complain to the police for fear of drawing attention to themselves. Werther blamed the boys' behavior on the hatred preached against his kind by clergymen and doctors, the professional men to whom his memoir was addressed. Charles Nesbitt also noted the "peculiar type of savage violence to which [such men] were subjected by the non-sympathetic in their own social stratum," in his memoir concerning his trip to New York around

1890.⁴¹ The fairies' conventionally feminine behavior also led thieves to expect little resistance from them. Two undercover agents discovered this in 1920 when three thieves tried to rob them "because they thought we were a couple fairies" and that it would thus be "a soft job."⁴²

Such violence often served a more instrumental purpose in reinforcing the boundaries between fairies and other men. Some men beat or robbed their effeminate male sexual partners after sex as if to emphasize that they felt no connection to them and had simply "used" them for sexual release. Although not a regular phenomenon, this happened often enough that many gay men interested in sex with straight men sought to avoid the situations in which it could happen most easily.⁴³

In some cases the violence directed against fairies may have represented an intersection of gender and class hostilities. Werther reported that he had been subjected to gang rapes by several of the Irish and Italian youth gangs he approached.⁴⁴ In this his fate was no different from that of women whom men considered sexually available; if fairies were tolerated because they were regarded as women, they were also subject to the contempt and violence regularly directed against women. Fairies, like women who crossed certain lines (even such narrow ones as daring to walk down certain streets alone, without male guardianship), were considered fair game by many gangs. Werther's situation was complicated by the fact that it must have been obvious to such gangs that he was not a "fairy of the slums," but an uptown gentleman out slumming. One suspects that he became a convenient target for working-class men's resentment of the upper-class gentlemen who visited their neighborhood for purposes of slumming and using "their" women. If working-class men often tried to claim a certain gender superiority over effete gentlemen on the basis of their supposed greater masculinity, they could ritually enact and enhance that sense of superiority by their sexual subjection and brutalization of the homosexual gentlemen who came their way.⁴⁵

The mixture of tolerance, desire, and contempt with which men regarded fairies also resulted from the particular *kind* of feminine role they adopted. Although I have argued that fairies were considered womanlike in their behavior and self-representation, that is really too imprecise a formulation. For no single norm governing "feminine" (or "masculine") behavior existed at the turn of the century; such normative injunctions varied along class lines and among immigrant groups and, indeed, became one of the standards by which such groups constituted themselves and distinguished themselves from others. In crucial

respects the fairies' style was comparable not so much to that of some ideal category of womanhood as to that of a particular subgroup of women or cultural type: prostitutes and other so-called "tough girls."⁴⁶ The fairy's sexual aggressiveness in his solicitation of men was certainly inconsistent with the sexual passivity expected of a respectable woman, but it was entirely in keeping with the sexual character ascribed to tough girls and prostitutes. That gay men themselves shared this identification accounts, in part, for the popularity of "strong" or "tough" women, such as Mae West, as gay icons and drag personas: they were regarded as women who disdained convention, were determinedly and overtly sexual in character, and did what they needed to get what they wanted.

Moreover, both fairies and prostitutes congregated in many of the same locales and used some of the same techniques to attract attention; the fairy's most obvious attribute, his painted face, was the quintessential marker of the prostitute.⁴⁷ And while fairies, like prostitutes, played the so-called woman's part in sexual relations with men, both groups engaged in certain forms of sexual behavior, particularly oral sex, which many working-class and middle-class women alike rejected as unbecoming to a woman, "dirty," and "perverted."⁴⁸ (Anti-vice investigators called prostitutes who performed fellation "perverts," the same term they applied to the men who performed it.)⁴⁹ The fairies' style, then, was not so much an imitation of women as a group but a provocative exaggeration of the appearance and demeanor ascribed more specifically to prostitutes. As a result, many men seem to have regarded fairies in the same terms they regarded prostitutes. This conflation may have made it easier for them to distance themselves from fairies and to use them for sexual purposes in the same way they used female prostitutes.⁵⁰

The men who adopted the styles of the fairy boldly announced to the world that they were sexually different from other men and that they sexually desired other men. They made their existence obvious to everyone in the city and provoked a range of responses from "normal" men: desire, contempt, fascination, abuse. Becoming a fairy offered men a way to make sense of their feeling sexually different from other men and to structure their relations with other men. Because the fairy was the central pejorative category against which men had to measure themselves as they developed their gender and sexual style, all men had to position themselves in relation to it. Some men who desired other men, as we shall see, rejected the style and identity of the fairy alto-

gether, but that style and identity had numerous meanings even to the men who embraced it. Some men, like Ralph Werther, identified with the image of the fairy completely; becoming a fairy seemed a “natural” way to express their “true” feminine natures. Many other men had a more complicated and distant relation to the persona of the fairy, adopting it in a more calculated and strategic manner in order to negotiate their relations with other men. Using the style of the fairy allowed them to announce their identities to gay and straight men alike in the settings in which they wished to do so. It also allowed them to attract “normal” men who would interact with them publicly only if they behaved in a manner that was appealing and that made it clear to onlookers who would play the “woman’s part” in their sexual relations.

Gay men themselves believed that such effeminacy was more natural to some men than others. “If not naturally, we tried to walk very effeminately, talk very effeminately, look effeminate, use rouge and make-up, etc., to impersonate a female,” commented one man, to whom such effeminacy did not come so “naturally” as it did to others, in the early 1920s.⁵¹ Parker Tyler noted the strategic purposes served by such styles more directly: as he wrote to a gay friend in 1931, he only adopted them in order to avoid “insulting” a group of “inferior males all dying except certain ones to believe i am dying for them.”⁵²

The very ability of gay men to act this way—to transform themselves into fairies or quasi-women by changing their dress or demeanor—both highlights and can only be understood in the context of the plasticity of gender assignment in the rough working-class culture in which the fairies operated. As one gay man explained in the mid-1920s: “It is well known fact”—widely believed, apparently, in his circles, at least—

that the secret of a woman’s appeal to man is not so much her sex as her effeminacy. . . . The attitude of the average man to the homosexual is determined by the degree of effeminacy in the homosexual. Your writer has observed that nine out of ten [men] take favorably to the homosexual. Of course, they seek the eternal feminine in the homosexual . . . [and] feminine homosexuals naturally have the greater number of admirers.⁵³

He, in other words, not only imagined that cultural gender could be dissociated from anatomical sex, but that the former was more significant in erotic attraction and in everyday social interactions than the latter. His comment, which is echoed by many others, also suggests that the working-class men with whom he interacted were more capable of distinguishing cultural gender from anatomical sex than their middle-class

contemporaries were; the latter were more likely to object to homosexual men of any sort. To explain why workingmen found it easier to interact with fairies than middle-class men did, we need to explore the distinctive sexual cultures of working-class and middle-class men in the early twentieth century.



Figure 3.1 *The Fleet's In* (1934), a painting by the gay artist Paul Cadmus, depicts the efforts of women and gay men alike to seduce sailors. The man offering a cigarette to the sailor has the typical markers of a fairy: bleached hair, tweezed eyebrows, rouged cheeks, and red tie. The sailor's eyes suggest he knows exactly what is being offered along with the smoke. (Courtesy of Navy Art Collection; detail from painting shown.)

49. Moreover, it was those women who refused to engage in “abnormal” sexual practices such as oral sex—not specifically those who rejected lesbian behavior—who were considered “straight.” See, for example, the language used by an agent to report two prostitutes’ response to his query about their willingness to provide oral sex: “I first asked [them] if they were french (perverts); they replied, ‘Straight only’” (report on 269 1/2 W 22nd St., May 26, 1927, box 36, COF).

50. The association of male homosexuality with female prostitution was enshrined in the Wolfenden Report, published in Great Britain in 1957, which considered both phenomena in conjunction: *Report of the Committee on Homosexual Offenses and Prostitution, Sir John Wolfenden, Chairman* (1957; New York: Stein and Day, 1963). (For a further analysis of this association, see the following chapter.)

51. Quoted in Kahn, *Mentality and Homosexuality*, 127

52. Parker Tyler to Charles Henri Ford, c. Feb. 18, 1931.

53. Quoted in Kahn, *Mentality and Homosexuality*, 155.

CHAPTER 3. TRADE, WOLVES, AND THE BOUNDARIES OF NORMAL MANHOOD

1. Report on Times Square Building by J. K., May 2, 1927, COF. “D—” in the original.

2. *Happy Hour Bar & Grill, Inc., v. Bruckman, et al.*, 256 A.D. 1074 (2nd Dep’t 1939), reports on the Happy Hour Bar & Grill by investigators Tierney and Kirschenbaum, dated Oct. 10 and Oct. 17, 1938, contained in Record on Review, 47–48, 56.

3. E. S. Shepherd, for example, specifically referred to “fairies” as “the male prostitute of the streets” in “Contribution to the Study of Intermediacy,” *American Journal of Urology and Sexology* 14 (1918): 245.

4. Richard Meeker, *Better Angel* (New York: Greenberg, 1933), 259; Kennilworth Bruce, *Goldie* (New York: William Godwin, 1933), 105.

5. Gershon Legman, “The Language of Homosexuality: An American Glossary,” in George W. Henry, *Sex Variants* (New York: Paul B. Hoeber, 1941), vol. 2, appendix VII, 1176, quoting a study of prostitutes’ slang; *Report and Proceedings of the [Lexow] Senate Committee appointed to investigate the Police Department of the City of New York* (Albany: J. B. Lyon, 1895), Captain Ryan testimony, 5591.

6. Charles W. Gardner, *The Doctor and the Devil; or, the Midnight Adventures of Dr. Parkhurst* (New York: Gardner & Co., 1894), 52.

7. R. W. Shufeldt, M.D., “Biography of a Passive Pederast,” *American Journal of Urology and Sexology* 13 (1917): 451–60. Although the interview was reported in 1917, it took place in 1906. “Looping the loop” had become a generic slang expression for such amusement park rides in the 1900s; see Jane Addams’s reference to “looping the loop” in *The Spirit of Youth and the City Streets* (New York: Macmillan, 1909), 69, as quoted in John F. Kasson, *Amusing the Million: Coney Island at the Turn of the Century* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1978), 100, who also discusses the ride on pp. 81–82.

8. Quoted in George Chauncey, “Christian Brotherhood or Sexual Perversion? Homosexual Identities and the Construction of Sexual Boundaries in the World War One Era,” *Journal of Social History* 19 (1985): 195. The sailor was questioned at the Newport, Rhode Island, naval training station, but had spent time in New York and was involved in a gay world not far removed from that of the city.

9. R. E. Fay, C. F. Turner, A. D. Klassen, and J. H. Gagnon, “Prevalence and

Patterns of Same-Gender Sexual Contact Among Men," *Science* 243 (1989): 343–48; S. M. Rogers and C. F. Turner, "Male–Male Sexual Contact in the USA: Findings from Five Sample Surveys, 1970–1990," *Journal of Sex Research* 28 (1991): 491–519; J. O. G. Billy, K. Panfer, W. R. Grady, and D. H. Klepinger, "The Sexual Behavior of Men in the United States," *Family Planning Perspectives* 25 (1993): 52–60.

10. Alfred Kinsey, Wardell Pomeroy, and Clyde Martin, *Sexual Behavior in the Human Male* (Philadelphia: W. B. Saunders, 1948), 612, 614.

11. *Ibid.*, 616.

12. The reputation of Italian men for trade in the gay world was noted by Frank Burton, Bruce Nugent, and Sebastian Risicato in interviews; see also the role of Italian men in Charles Henri Ford and Parker Tyler, *The Young and Evil* (Paris: Obelisk Press, 1933), which was based on Tyler's experiences in the Village, where he regularly encountered "straight" Italian men interested in sex with men. On Irish men, see the discussion of Charles Tomlinson Griffes and policemen in the following chapter. I have been unable to locate sufficient evidence concerning the sexual cultures of other immigrant groups in New York to propose even a tentative analysis of them. New York City's small Chinatown community, for instance, consisted almost entirely of bachelors as a result of restrictive immigration policies. While slender oral history evidence hints at homosexual activity among some of the bachelors, there is not a single gay-related reference (and virtually no reference of any kind) to Chinese men in the records of the Committee of Fourteen and Committee of Fifteen I have examined. The single sodomy case I have found concerns an unmarried twenty-four-year-old Chinese laundryman, who allegedly forced sex on two Jewish boys he enticed into the premises of a laundry on East Broadway one evening in 1898. He was acquitted, and the DAP case file contains no additional information (*People v. Ong*, DAP 22,086 [CGS 1898]).

13. Frederick H. Whitin, "Sexual Perversion Cases in New York City Courts, 1916–1921," bulletin 1480, Nov. 12, 1921, box 88, COF. My review of the backgrounds of the two hundred men arrested by the police (with the assistance of the Society for the Suppression of Vice) for degenerate disorderly conduct in 1920–21 suggests that almost twice as many Italians than Jews were arrested (see the eleven-page list, untitled, in "Homosexuality" folder, box 63, COF). Religious and national backgrounds for most (but not all) of the men arrested were supplied in the records of the Society itself, volumes 3–5 (SSV). These figures, of course, may reveal as much about the enforcement priorities of the police as about the actual incidence of homosexual conduct. I include them, however, as one piece of evidence for the pattern of ethnic differences suggested more conclusively by the greater visibility and institutionalization of gay life in the Italian than Jewish Lower East Side.

14. 207 Canal St. report, "Court of Special Sessions [cases]," box 65, COF. A judge ultimately refused to close the saloon on the basis of "disorderly conversation" alone.

15. Report of J. R., Mar. 22, 1901, box 7, Committee of Fifteen papers, NYPL.

16. Report of H. S. Conklin, Mar. 5, 1901, box 5; report of Salomon and Robinson, February 1901, box 7, Committee of Fifteen papers, NYPL. According to the typed transcript of the investigators' notes cited here, the five boys were known as "faniss," by which they may have meant "finocchio," the Italian-American term for fennel, used in the production of licorice, which Italian-Americans used synonymously with the English term cocksucker. (This presumably was the origin of the name of Finocchio's, a famous club in San Francisco featuring

a female-impersonation act in the 1940s and 1950s.) Other investigators' reports refer to such men as "fairies," as well as "perverts" and, most commonly, "cock suckers." "Pansy" did not become a common term for gay men until the 1920s.

17 Report of Captain Titus [to the Mayor], Dec. 20, 1900, box 9, Van Wyck papers, Mayors' Papers, NYMA. The same report notes that the police investigated rumors that 138 Chrystie St. was a disorderly house, but does not indicate what kind of "disorder" was said to occur there. I am indebted to Timothy Gilfoyle for this reference.

18. Kinsey, *Sexual Behavior*, 483. On Italian immigrants' response to church teachings, see Robert Orsi, *The Madonna of 115th Street: Faith and Community in Italian Harlem, 1880–1950* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1985), xvi–xviii, 219–21; Gary R. Mormino and George E. Pozzetta, *The Immigrant World of Ybor City: Italians and Their Latin Neighbors in Tampa, 1885–1985* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1987), 210–32.

19. Kinsey also noted that many sexologists in Italy itself considered southern Italy "the most homosexual place in the world," although he continued to believe that homosexual behavior was more widespread in several countries in the Middle and Far East. See Wardell Pomeroy, *Dr. Kinsey and the Institute for Sex Research* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1972), 423–27. On the general openness of Italian men to sexual contacts with men, see also the letters from one of Kinsey's informants reprinted in Martin Duberman, *About Time: Exploring the Gay Past* (New York: Gay Presses of New York, 1986), 173–77. For one gay veteran's view of homosexual life in Italy, see John Hope Burns's postwar novel, *The Gallery* (New York: Harper, 1947). On instrumentalist approaches to the body, see Pierre Bourdieu's observations in "Sport and Social Class," *Social Science Information* 17 (1978): 819–40. Bourdieu argues that such attitudes are more characteristic of (French) working-class men than middle-class men, but unfortunately does not historicize that assessment. Although the homosexual culture on the Lower East Side bears a remarkable resemblance in many respects to the limited accounts we have of Mediterranean sexual patterns, the subtle variations in those patterns, both within the Mediterranean basin and between Europe and the United States, need to be studied with care. "Mediterranean" cultures are often represented as more homogeneous in such matters than they actually are. On the dangers of such homogenization, see, for example, Michael Herzfeld, "The Horns of the Mediterraneanist Dilemma," *American Ethnologist* 11 (1984): 439–54. See also John J. Winkler, *Constraints of Desire* (New York: Routledge, 1990).

20. On the different demographic patterns of Italian and Jewish immigration to New York, see Thomas Kessner, *The Golden Door: Italian and Jewish Immigrant Mobility in New York City* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1977), 26–32. On the unusually large number of single men who immigrated to the United States from Italy, see also Dino Cinel, *From Italy to San Francisco: The Immigrant Experience* (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 1982), 162–72. For an analytic overview of the circumstances in Europe and the Americas that resulted in European emigration and of the significance of family networks to migration, see John Bodnar, *The Transplanted: A History of Immigrants in Urban America* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1985), 1–84. Numerous historians have studied Italian and Jewish immigration to New York. See, for example, Moses Rischin, *The Promised City: New York's Jews, 1870–1914* (Cambridge, Mass. Harvard University Press, 1962); Irving Howe, *World of Our Fathers* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1976); Donna R. Gabaccia, *From Sicily to Elizabeth Street: Housing and Social Change Among Italian Immigrants* (Albany:

State University of New York Press, 1984); as well as the other studies cited elsewhere in this section.

21. Sophonisba Breckinridge, *New Homes for Old* (New York: Harper, 1921), 176-77. See also Susan A. Glenn, *Daughters of the Shtetl: Life and Labor in the Immigrant Generation* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1990), 81-82, 159-66, 162, 215-16. On the greater degree of social interaction between men and women in Jewish than Italian neighborhoods, see also Kathy Peiss, *Cheap Amusements: Working Women and Leisure in Turn-of-the-Century New York* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1986), 30, 68; Elizabeth Ewen, *Immigrant Women in the Land of Dollars: Life and Culture on the Lower East Side, 1890-1925* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1985), 210-11; Elinor Lerner, "Family Structure, Occupational Patterns, and Support for Women's Suffrage," in *Women in Culture and Politics: A Century of Change*, ed. Judith Friedlander et al. (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1986); Gabaccia, *From Sicily*, 97.

22. Orsi, *The Madonna of 115th Street*, 21, 115-17, 135-43. On living arrangements, see Kessner, *The Golden Door*, 99-101; and Gabaccia, *From Sicily*, ch. 5-6. On the use of leisure time, see Perry R. Duis, *The Saloon: Public Drinking in Chicago and Boston, 1880-1920* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1983), 146-48, Louise C. Odencrantz, *Italian Women in Industry: A Study of Conditions in New York* (New York: Russell Sage), 203-5, who noted that in such families "the mother had no recreation and [even] the father took his alone" (203), and Gabaccia, *From Sicily*, 97.

23. John H. Mariano, *The Second Generation of Italians in New York City* (Boston: Christopher Publishing, 1921), 140-43. For a fine analysis of such social clubs and gangs, see Leonard H. Ellis, "Men Among Men: An Exploration of All-Male Relationships in Victorian America" (Ph.D. diss., Columbia University, 1982), 1-60. Ellis assumes too readily that boys usually left such gangs for poolrooms and saloons once they reached the age of sixteen or eighteen, but he offers a thoughtful analysis of the role of all three such neighborhood-based all-male social groupings and spaces in the everyday lives of late-nineteenth-century men.

24. For a fascinating analysis of the origins and social organization of the Irish bachelor culture, see Richard Stivers, *A Hair of the Dog: Irish Drinking and American Stereotype* (University Park: Pennsylvania State University Press, 1976). For evidence of the concern the high rates of bachelorhood and spinsterhood provoked among Irish and Catholic leaders, see the articles cited by Stivers: James Walsh, "Catholic Bachelors and Old Maids," *America*, Aug. 12, 1922, 389-90; idem, "The Disappearing Irish in America," *America*, May 1, 1926, 56-57; idem, "Shy Irish Bachelors," *America*, Mar. 29 1930, 592-93; M. V. Kelly, "The Suicide of the Irish Race," *America*, Nov. 17 and 24, 1928, 128-29, 155-56.

25. The paintings by Cadmus and Demuth of sailors in homoerotic situations appear in many of the catalogs of their work. In addition to the Cadmus painting reproduced at the beginning of this chapter, see the paintings reproduced in the catalog for the Demuth retrospective at the Whitney Museum of American Art, *Charles Demuth* (New York: Abrams, 1987). For later pornographers, see almost any issue of *Tomorrow's Man*, *VIM*, *Physique Pictorial*, and the other gay-oriented "physique magazines" published in the 1940s-1960s.

26. On the decline of the transient workforce, see Nels Anderson, *Men on the Move* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1940), 2-5, 12.

27. There were also ethnic, occupational, and generational differences among the men in the various male subcultures that collectively constituted the "bachelor subculture," but most of them shared its distinctive characteristics to some degree.

28. Ralph Werther, *Autobiography of an Androgyne* (New York: Medico-Legal Journal, 1918), 83–84, 88.

29. Report on the Subway Cabaret, Fourteenth St. near Fourth Ave., 10 P.M., Jan. 12, 1917, COF.

30. On the importance of what he calls “masculine conviviality” to such men, the character of the bachelor subculture, and the relationship between the culture of the “rough” working class and the respectable, see David Montgomery, *The Fall of the House of Labor: The Workplace, the State, and American Labor Activism, 1865–1925* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 87–92; Roy Rosenzweig, *Eight Hours for What We Will: Workers and Leisure in an Industrial City, 1870–1920* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1983), 57–64, 74–81; Elliott J. Gorn, *The Manly Art: Bare-Knuckle Prize Fighting in America* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1986), 129–45, especially 140–45; Ned Polsky, *Hustlers, Beats, and Others* (Chicago: Aldine, 1967), 31–37, 90, 105, 109–10; Ellis, “Men Among Men,” 1–60; and Peter Bailey, “‘Will the Real Bill Banks Please Stand Up?’ Towards a Role Analysis of Mid-Victorian Working-Class Respectability,” in *Expanding the Past: Essays from the Journal of Social History*, ed. Peter N. Stearns (New York: New York University Press, 1988), 73–90.

31. For two distinct perspectives on the performativity of everyday life, see Erving Goffman’s classic study, *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1959); and Judith Butler’s splendid *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990).

32. On the carnival, see Peter Stallybrass and Allon White, *The Politics and Poetics of Transgression* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1986).

33. Antonio L., quoted in Henry, *Sex Variants*, 420.

34. Report on Italian Restaurant, 207 W. 17th St., Oct. 6, 1927, box 36, COF.

35. Frederick H. Whitin to Captain T. N. Pfeiffer, War and Navy Departments Commission, Washington, Apr. 3, 1918, box 25, COF.

36. J. A. S., Conditions about the Brooklyn Navy Yard, June 6, 1917, box 25, COF. See also, for example, Harry Benjamin’s 1931 article arguing that “the suppression of prostitution [in New York] has probably increased and favored homosexual tendencies and practices” (“For the Sake of Morality,” *Medical Journal and Record* 133: 380–82).

37. For more on the sexual mapping of the city, see chapter 7.

38. On the magnitude of the business of prostitution in nineteenth- and early-twentieth-century New York City, and its decline after the 1910s, see Timothy J. Gilfoyle, *City of Eros: New York City, Prostitution, and the Commercialization of Sex, 1790–1920* (New York: Norton, 1992).

39. Kinsey, *Sexual Behavior*, 38; William Foote Whyte, “A Slum Sex Code,” *American Journal of Sociology* 49 (1943): 24–31.

40. On the belief that men had to have regular orgasms to maintain their health, see Charles Rosenberg, “Sexuality, Class, and Role in Nineteenth-Century America,” in *The American Man*, ed. Elizabeth H. Pleck and Joseph H. Pleck (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1980), 230–32, and E. Anthony Rotundo, *American Manhood: Transformations in Masculinity from the Revolution to the Modern Era* (New York: Basic Books, 1993), 121–22. Both accounts focus on the nineteenth century, but it is clear that the belief persisted into the twentieth. For examples of the term *satisfaction* used casually to mean orgasm, see, for example, Salvatore N., quoted in Henry, *Sex Variants*, 176; Victor F. Nelson, *Prison Days and Nights* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1933), 157–58.

41. Finch diary, Aug. 8, 1949, KIL.

42. "Social Contagion in the Pool-room," 14–15, in Frederic M. Thrasher, "The Use of the Superior Boy in Research," BSH, box 11, folder 229 ("NYU Boys Club Study, 1930"), microfilm reel 6.

43. Shufeldt, "Biography of a Passive Pederast," 457.

44. "Sex Practices and Stimuli," 12–13, in Thrasher.

45. Finch diary, Jan. 3, 1951. Committee of Fourteen investigators regularly reported that even prostitutes were unwilling to engage in oral sex; see, for example, the reports on 269 1/2 W 22nd St., May 26, 1927; tenement, 756 Eighth Ave., Dec. 4, 1928; tenement, 2544 Eighth Ave., June 21, 1928; Navarre Hotel, Seventh Ave. and 38th St., Mar. 16, 1928, box 36, COF. Not all women rejected such requests, however; see the reports on tenement, 954 Eighth Ave., Sept. 20, 1927 ("I don't make a practice of it, but if you want it, I'll accommodate you"); tenement, 42 W. 46th St., July 22, 1927; and B&G Sandwich Shop, 140 Fulton St., Dec. 19, 1927 (the woman there said "the only way I do it is the French way," explaining that she did not want to risk pregnancy), all in the same file.

46. Allan M. Brandt, *No Magic Bullet: A Social History of Venereal Disease in the United States Since 1880* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1985), ch. 2–3, provides the best account of such campaigns. On men's fear of catching a disease from a prostitute, see, for example, Report on Maxim's, 108 W 38th St., Sept. 25, 1916, box 31, COF. In significant respects such campaigns prefigured the AIDS education campaigns of the early 1980s, which often identified sex with a gay man or an IV-drug user, rather than sex without a condom, as the source of AIDS. Such campaigns led many people to fear that the most casual contact with certain categories of people was unsafe, while reassuring them, with deadly inaccuracy, of the safety of the most intimate contact with other categories of people.

47. Report on Hanover Lunch, 2 South St., June 12, 1931, box 35, COF. Gene Harwood and Frank Burton, in discussing their memories of the 1920s and 1930s in an interview with the author, also pointed to men's fear of getting venereal diseases from women as a reason for their willingness to have sex with gay men. The sociologist Nels Anderson also reported that hoboes argued they were less likely to catch a venereal disease from homosexual than from heterosexual intercourse (*The Hobo: The Sociology of the Homeless Man* [Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1923], 134, 147–48), a view shared by the Chicago Vice Commission in its 1911 report, *The Social Evil in Chicago*, 296–97, cited in Anderson, 148. See also Samuel Kahn, *Mentality and Homosexuality* (Boston: Meador, 1937), 50–51. For indications that this belief was of long standing, see Randolph Trumbach, "The Birth of the Queen: Sodomy and the Emergence of Gender Equality in Modern Culture, 1660–1750," in *Hidden from History: Reclaiming the Gay and Lesbian Past*, ed. Martin Duberman, Martha Vicinus, and George Chauncey (New York: New American Library, 1989), 129–40.

48. Bulletin 1504, Mar. 24, 1922, box 88, COF.

49. Shufeldt, "Biography of a Passive Pederast," 459, 456.

50. Will Finch thought the latter, although he sometimes substituted the older Navy word *pogue* for the more generally used *punk*. As he commented of one young Norwegian sailor, an older sailor's "boy" who nonetheless ended up in bed with Finch one summer night in 1946 and made it clear he expected Finch to anally penetrate (or "brown") him: "I decided that he was either queer and *liked* to be browned or the big guy's pogue and *expected* to be browned" (Finch diary, July 14, 1946). On the widespread use of *pogue* by sailors in the World War I era to mean a man who desired to be browned, see Chauncey, "Christian Brotherhood or Sexual Perversion?" especially 192, 196. The evidence suggests that the young men to whom the term was applied fell into all three camps.

51. Alexander Berkman, *Prison Memoirs of an Anarchist* (New York: Mother Earth Publishing Association, 1912), 170, 172. Joseph F. Fishman, the first federal Inspector of Prisons and, in the late 1920s, the Deputy Commissioner of the New York City Department of Corrections, used the word *wolf* for the aggressive party in homosexual encounters in his description of prison homosexuality among non-homosexuals, in *Sex in Prison* (New York: National Library Press, 1934), 152, as did his critic, Louis Berg, *Revelations of a Prison Doctor* (New York: Milton, Balch, 1934), 120, 142. For evidence of the use of such terms among hoboes in the 1910s–1930s, see Anderson, *The Hobo*, 99, 101, 103, 144–48 (*wolf*, *jocker*, *lamb*, *kid*, *wife*, and *punk*), and *Broadway Brevities*, Nov. 9, 1931, 10. In the novel *Goldie*, a sailor approached the protagonist, who was hustling on Times Square, called himself “the slickest wolf in ther navy,” and added, in reference to the hustler, “I guess I ought ter know a regular punk when I sees one” (116). The terms were also used in Los Angeles by the 1920s, according to Aaron J. Rosanoff, “Human Sexuality, Normal and Abnormal, from a Psychiatric Standpoint,” *Urologic and Cutaneous Review* (1929), 528. *Punk* was also widely used in the criminal underworld beyond the prison walls, specifically to refer to the underlings in a criminal gang and more generally as an epithet; see, for example, its use in Cornelius Willemse, *Behind the Green Lights* (New York, 1931), 336–37. On the term’s diffusion into general slang, see Legman, “The Language of Homosexuality,” 1174. The terms were still used with similar sexual meanings in prisons in the 1970s; see Wayne S. Wooden and Jay Parker, *Men Behind Bars: Sexual Exploitation in Prison* (New York: Da Capo, 1982).

52. The distinction between “wolves” and homosexuals (or “queers”) persisted. One hustler picked up in 1949 by a conventionally masculine queer, Will Finch, queried whether he were “‘just queer or a wolf,’” adding that there was “no use in ‘getting up there and finding out it’s no use,’” which Finch took to mean that “he won’t be pedicated” (Finch diary, May 20, 1949). The hustler, in other words, insisted on remaining the man in the encounter, which he could do if he were sexually serviced by a queer, and refused to be feminized by being pedicated by a wolf. Finch’s response, that he was “not a wolf—unless [the hustler] wants me to be,” suggests that, at least by the postwar period, *wolf* described a sexual role as much as a social or characterological “type.”

53. Report on the Seamen’s Church Institute and vicinity, July 15 and 16, 1931, COF.

54. Reports on the Seamen’s Church Institute and vicinity, May 27, June 22, July 2, and July 15 and 16, 1931, COF.

55. Ibid.

56. Rev. Frank Charles Laubach, “Why There Are Vagrants: Based upon an Examination of One Hundred Men” (Ph.D. diss., Columbia University, 1916), 13–14, reported that twenty-four of the hundred men were perverts. A 1935 survey of ninety men housed in a Chicago shelter for the homeless noted that “7 percent stated they were engaging in homosexual practices” (Edwin J. Sutherland and Harvey J. Locke, *Twenty Thousand Homeless Men: A Study of Unemployed Men in the Chicago Shelters* [Chicago: Lippincott, 1936], 131). The 7 percent figure is almost surely low: not only does it report the number of men who “stated” they were homosexually active, something many such men would doubtless deny to people surveying them in a homeless shelter, but the figure was produced during the Depression, when a more diverse group of men had been made homeless.

57. Dean Stiff [pseudonym of Nels Anderson], *The Milk and Honey Route: A Handbook for Hobos* (New York: Vanguard Press, 1931), 161.

58. Anderson, *The Hobo*, 145.

59. Important early efforts to investigate such social worlds from this perspective include Susan Lee Johnson's "The Gold She Gathered": Difference, Domination, and California's Southern Mines, 1848–1853" (Ph.D. diss., Yale University, 1993); B. R. Burg, *Sodomy and the Pirate Tradition: English Sea Rovers in the Seventeenth-Century Caribbean* (New York: New York University Press, 1984); Chad Heap, "The Melting Pot of Trampdom," unpublished seminar paper, University of Chicago, 1993.

60. Wooden and Parker, *Men Behind Bars*.

61. Berg, *Revelations of a Prison Doctor*, 137, 152–61; Kahn, *Mentality and Homosexuality*, 23–24, 129; see also Perry M. Lichtenstein, "The 'Fairy' and the Lady Lover," *Medical Review of Reviews* 27 (1921): 369–74.

62. *New York Herald Tribune*, Jan. 27, 1934, 2.

63. Berg, *Revelations of a Prison Doctor*, 161–63.

64. The raid has not received much attention from historians, but for La Guardia's appointment of Austin H. MacCormick as Commissioner of Corrections and his insistence that the Tammany influence be driven from the Corrections Department, see Lowell M. Limpus and Burr W. Leyson, *This Man La Guardia* (New York: Dutton, 1938), 378, 381, and Thomas Kessner, *Fiorello H. La Guardia and the Making of Modern New York* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1989), ch. 8.

65. "M'Cormick Raids Welfare Island, Smashes Gangster Rule of Prison; Warden Relieved, Deputy Seized: Commissioner Discovers Top Notch Thugs Living at Ease in Hospital . . . Private Section Housing Degenerates Revealed in 'World's Worst' Bastille; Flare-Up Feared," *New York Herald Tribune*, Jan. 25, 1934, 1, 9; "McCann Admits 'Convict Rule,'" *Daily Mirror*, Jan. 26, 1934, 10. In yet another article in the same issue, "Welfare Milk Racket Bared," 3, the paper asked "why 'Greta Garbo,' alias 'Top and Bottom,' the drug-eaten former U.S. Navy goby, wears his hair to his waist." The *New York Times* also gave the prison raid extensive coverage. Although it paid less attention to the most scandalous elements, even it described the "altogether different line of contraband" found in the homosexual cell block, including "rouge, powder, mascara, perfume, even a woman's wig," and went on to describe how "several of the inmates of this cell block affected long hair. Silk undergarments were found in the cells" ("Welfare Island Raid Bares Gangster Rule Over Prison; Weapons, Narcotics Found . . . Vice Carried on Openly," Jan. 25, 1934, 3).

66. In addition to the studies already cited, see Joseph F. Fishman, *Sex in Prison: Revealing Sex Conditions in American Prisons* (New York: National Library Press, 1934). The growth of interest in homosexuality in prisons may account for the publication of Samuel Kahn's study, *Mentality and Homosexuality*, in 1937, even though it had been written more than a decade earlier.

67. Thomas Mott Osborne, *Prisons and Common Sense* (Philadelphia: Lippincott, 1924), 89–90. He also recognized a third category: "the degenerates, whose dual nature [combining male and female elements] has been a problem to the psychologist since the days of ancient Greece."

68. Nelson, *Prison Days and Nights*, 157–58. Note the assumption that male and female fellators were equally anomalous and virtually interchangeable.

CHAPTER 4. THE FORGING OF QUEER IDENTITIES AND THE EMERGENCE OF HETEROSEXUALITY IN MIDDLE-CLASS CULTURE

1. E. S. Shepherd, "Contribution to the Study of Intermediacy," *American Journal of Urology and Sexology* 14 (1918): 245.

2. Richard Meeker [pseud. of Forman Brown], *Better Angel* (New York: Greenberg, 1933), 259.